LIBS 7102 Midterm · Side 1: definitions, lists, lectures 1 and 3 Closed book: read this the night before and the morning of. Wednesday Oct 28.

Definitions, word for word

- **Valid (L1 s18):** the truth of the premises guarantees the truth of the conclusion; truth-preserving; valid regardless of whether premises or conclusion are true.
- **Sound (L1 s21):** sound if and only if the argument is valid and all the premises are true; validity is necessary but not sufficient.
- **Claims (L1 s28):** empirical: sensory tests alone settle it; value: approval/disapproval not reducible to an empirical claim (moral, aesthetic); conceptual: the meaning of the words alone settles it.
- **No ought from is (L1 s14):** moral value cannot ever be established from empirical facts alone; every moral argument needs a value premise.
- **No ought without can (L1 s14):** there can be no moral requirement to do something unless this is possible.
- **Moral objectivism (Pojman, L3 s28):** there is a fact of the matter as to whether any given action is morally permissible or impermissible: a fact of the matter that does not depend solely on social custom or individual acceptance.
- **Moral absolutism (Pojman, L3 s28):** there is at least one principle that ought never to be violated.
- **ECI (L4 s15):** the pleasure or pain of one person should be of no more value than the pleasure or pain of another; not equal treatment or just distribution; may benefit only one.
- **Right action (L4 s24):** an action is right if and only if there is no other available action the agent could have done instead that has higher utility; utility = pleasure − pain.
- **The procedure (L5 s8):** 1) identify all affected by the available options; 2) for each option aggregate all utility (pleasure and pain, with ECI) on the actual outcome; 3) choose the option that maximizes utility.

Kohlberg's stages (L2 s16)

1. Obedience and punishment (preconventional)
2. Individualism and exchange (preconventional)
3. Good boy / good girl (conventional)
4. Law and order (conventional)
5. 4.5 The cynic: questions the conventional, no belief in the postconventional
6. Social contract and individual rights (postconventional)
7. Universal moral principles (postconventional)

Rachels's six claims (L3 s17)

1. Different societies have different moral codes (descriptive: true, empirical)
2. No objective standard judges one code better than another
3. Our own society's code has no special status
4. No universal truth in ethics
5. A society's code determines what is right in that society
6. It is arrogance to judge other peoples; we should be tolerant (2-6 normative: a mistake)

Bentham's felicific calculus (L4 s18)

- intensity, duration, certainty, proximity, fecundity, purity, and extent (number of people affected)

Mill's four changes (L4 s22)

1. Quality as well as quantity of pleasure (Socrates dissatisfied)
2. Psychological hedonism kept, Bentham's psychological egoism rejected; internal sanctions: self-esteem, guilt, conscience
3. A proof of the principle of utility
4. Following social rules generally suffices; use utility when rules conflict

Mill's three objections and replies (L5 s11-18)

- Doctrine of swine: pleasure is fit only for swine. Reply: higher pleasures, competent judges. Doubts: who is competent, what if they disagree, is quality non-hedonistic?
- Too high for humanity: always acting for the general interest demands too much. Reply: confuses the rule of action with its motive. Doubt: Sandel's doctors
- Lack of time: no time to calculate. Reply: the whole past duration of the species; universal idiocy; experience

Nozick's three reasons not to plug in (L5 s23)

1. We want to do certain things, not just have the experience of doing them
2. We want to be a certain sort of person
3. The machine limits us to a man-made reality: no contact with any deeper reality

Fourteen objections (L5 s40)

1. Doctrine of swine
2. Lack of time
3. Too much for humanity
4. Psychological hedonism mistaken
5. Normative hedonism mistaken
6. Mill's proof fails
7. Aggregating utility: counter-intuitive results
8. Strong doctrine of negative responsibility
9. Trivial actions classed as wrong
10. Promises of little importance
11. Punishment need not be fair
12. Justice of little importance
13. Counter-intuitive view of supererogation
14. Perfect impartiality: inappropriate or impossible demands

Skeletons: Lecture 1

M *Here is an argument. Is it true?*

- says an argument cannot be true or false; only its claims can (slides 16, 23)
- judges it valid: true premises would guarantee the conclusion (slide 18)
- types P1 conceptual, P2 empirical, P3 and C value (slide 28)

Skeletons: Lecture 3: relativism

R1 *Distinguish descriptive ethical relativism from normative ethical relativism*

- defines descriptive relativism as the empirical claim that moral codes differ between societies, and says it is true (slide 17, claim 1)
- defines normative relativism as the claim that right and wrong are determined by one's society's code (claims 2–6), a mistake (slide 17)
- says one is about what people believe, the other about what is right

R2 *Distinguish objectivism from absolutism (careful with using Google/ChatGPT for definitions as you may find entirely different definitions! Consider the definition of objectivism as discussed in class, and Pojman's definition of absolutism as discussed in class)*

- gives Pojman's definition of objectivism: a fact of the matter not depending solely on social custom or individual acceptance (slide 28)
- gives Pojman's definition of absolutism: at least one principle that ought never to be violated (slide 28)
- says the two are independent: objectivists can be absolutist (Kant) or non-absolutist (utilitarians), and a relativist can be absolutist (slides 28–29, 36)

R3 *Is it true that only a relativist can be tolerant?*

- answers no: relativism is not a logical consequence of tolerance (slide 35)
- says tolerance is itself a value an objectivist can hold as objectively valid
- explains core values: tolerance is meaningful only outside one's core (slide 35)

R4 *Suppose that a normative moral relativist argues that "out of respect and tolerance, we ought not to criticize other cultures." Why is it problematic to argue this?*

- states normative relativism: no universal moral truths; each society's code determines right (slide 17)
- says the claim is a universal ought binding every culture, which relativism denies exists: self-refuting
- says a culture whose code endorses criticizing others would be right to do so by relativism's own lights

R5 *Identify two important arguments that can be raised against normative ethical relativism. Briefly discuss.*

- argument 1: the cultural differences argument is invalid, an ought from an is (slide 18)
- notes that an invalid argument does not show the conclusion false, so a second argument is needed (slide 19)
- argument 2: the reductio, naming at least two of the three consequences (no criticizing other societies, right = consult your society, no moral progress) (slide 19)

LIBS 7102 Midterm · Side 2: Kohlberg and utilitarianism skeletons

Each answer: two paragraphs. Position and definitions in course words, then the example and the objection or reply.

Skeletons: Lecture 2: Kohlberg

K1 *Name Kohlberg's six stages of moral development and briefly describe each.*
- groups the stages in three levels: preconventional 1–2, conventional 3–4, postconventional 5–6 (slide 16)
- describes stages 1 and 2: punishment and might makes right; self-interest with fair exchange
- describes stages 3 and 4: expectations and praise of others; laws for social order, authority seldom questioned

K2 *Can it be problematic to remain in the law and order stage (Kohlberg) of moral development?*
- describes stage 4: laws obeyed because they are useful for social order; authority seldom questioned (slide 20)
- says many adults never reach stages 5 and 6, or stall at 3 and 4 (slide 20, course notes)
- explains the problem: following laws because they are laws cannot detect an unjust or flawed law or convention

K3 *What is the conventional level of moral development (Kohlberg), and why is it not the final level?*
- defines the conventional level as stages 3 and 4: expectations of others, laws for social order (slides 19–20)
- says it is not final because conventions may be flawed or only accidentally right (course notes)
- states Singer's view that equality is a moral ideal, not a fact: equal consideration of interests, not the same rights (slides 26–27)

K4 *Why does Kohlberg describe a stage 6 of moral development?*
- states stage 5: laws improved through the social contract and democratic agreements (slide 22)
- says democracy can fail: the tyranny of the majority (slide 23)
- states stage 6: laws valid only insofar as grounded in justice (Martin Luther King)

Skeletons: Lectures 4 and 5: utilitarianism

U1 *Does utilitarianism ask us to maximize happiness for the majority (over 50%)?*
- answers no: utilitarianism maximizes total aggregated utility, however many are helped (l5 slide 6)
- states ECI: each person's pleasure and pain counts equally, but this is not equal treatment or just distribution (l4 slide 15)
- gives the row −2 −1 −2 +500 +5 or an example where a minority's large gain outweighs a majority's small loss (l4 slide 16)

U2 *Does utilitarianism ask us to do what causes more pleasure than pain?*
- answers no: right iff no available alternative has higher utility (l4 slide 24)
- defines utility as net pleasure minus pain
- says several options may give more pleasure than pain, and only the maximum is right (slide 7)

U3 *How can utilitarians know what to do, if moral evaluation is based on the actual consequences of actions they haven't done yet?*
- says utilitarians cannot know actual consequences in advance and the theory does not claim they can, while rightness still depends on the actual outcome, not the predicted one
- states that utilitarianism is a criterion of right, not a decision procedure; no calculation is required before acting (week 4 notes)
- gives Mill's reply: experience (not universal idiocy) tells us what actions tend to cause pain, e.g. lying, corruption, torture (Lecture 5 slide 18)

U4 *Utilitarianism says that we should consider interests equally. Does this mean that it advocates justice?*
- answers no: ECI counts interests equally in the sum but does not require equal treatment or just distribution
- states slide 33's point: equal consideration of interests, but utility is aggregated
- says justice and rights have only derivative value (slide 32)

U5 *What arguments can be raised against normative hedonism?*
- defines normative hedonism: pleasure the only intrinsic good, pain the only intrinsic bad (l4 slide 13)
- describes the experience machine and its features, including permanent and indistinguishable from reality (slide 22)
- says a normative hedonist should plug in, but most of us would not

U6 *What are the main advantages and disadvantages of Mill's inclusion of quality in the measurement of utility?*
- states Mill's view: quality as well as quantity, against Bentham's quantity only (l4 slide 22)
- advantage: answers the doctrine of swine objection (slides 12–13)
- explains the competent judges as the test of quality (l4 slide 25)

U7 *What is the "Too high for humanity" objection to utilitarianism, and how has Mill responded to it?*
- states the objection: it demands too much to require that people always act from the motive of promoting the general interest (slide 14)
- gives the neighbour example or an equivalent everyday act
- states Mill's reply: the objection confuses the rule of action with the motive of it; ethics gives the test of duty, not the sole motive (slide 15)

U8 *What is the "Doctrine of swine" objection to utilitarianism, and how has Mill responded to it?*
- states the objection: a life with no higher end than pleasure is a doctrine worthy only of swine (slide 12)
- says it targets the claim that pleasure is the only intrinsic good
- states Mill's reply: pleasures differ in quality as well as quantity (slide 13)

U9 *What is the "Lack of time" objection to utilitarianism, and how has Mill responded to it?*
- states the objection: no time before acting to calculate the effects on general happiness (slide 17)
- states the universal idiocy reply: any theory fails if its user is assumed to be an idiot (slide 18)
- says experience shows some kinds of action (lying, corruption, torture) tend to cause pain, so no need to calculate every time (slide 18)

U10 *What is Mill's justification (his "Proof") for the principle of utility?*
- gives the visible/desirable analogy in Mill's words (l4 slide 26)
- states the conclusion: happiness is desirable (good), and the general happiness is good for all; a desire-fulfilment theory of welfare (slide 24)
- gives the two readings of 'desirable': circular if it means can be desired, wrong if it means good (slide 24)

U11 *Why can it be problematic to aggregate utility?*
- defines aggregation: everyone's pleasure and pain added into one total, ECI, maximize (slide 8)
- states slide 25's question: aggregate all utility, or respect individual rights at a cost to general happiness
- says a great harm to one can be outweighed by many small gains, so rights have no weight of their own

U12 *How could advocating for perfect impartiality be a problem for utilitarianism?*
- states impartiality: distance and emotional proximity do not matter; friend or stranger (slides 34 to 35)
- uses the three kids or the 11 strangers versus family of 10
- gives A2: no ought without can; almost no one can be that impartial

U13 *What does utilitarianism say about keeping promises?*
- states that a promise is kept only when keeping it maximizes utility, so promises will rarely be kept (slide 28)
- says there is no intrinsic obligation; only the pain of breaking it counts
- uses the dying grandfather with the slide 30 utilities (bait +25 highest) or an equivalent

U14 *Are there supererogatory actions in utilitarianism?*
- answers no for classical act utilitarianism: the maximizing action is always required (slide 37)
- defines supererogation: beyond the call of duty, moral but optional
- gives Singer's strong version (comparable moral significance; marginal utility) and that he calls it correct (slide 36)

U15 *Punishment can produce utility through rehabilitation, deterrence or vengeance. Point out morally problematic aspects with each of these, within the framework of utilitarianism (consider the actions it could recommend)*
- rehabilitation: not a right or good in itself; life in solitary confinement if that maximizes utility (slide 32)
- deterrence: could recommend framing an innocent or convicting three to catch one guilty
- vengeance: the pleasure of enough people justifies any punishment; guilt not intrinsically relevant